

High court clears way for layoffs by Trump

Mass firings and agency overhauls can proceed as litigation continues

BY ANN E. MARIMOW

The Supreme Court on Tuesday cleared the way for the Trump administration to launch plans for mass firings and reorganizations at 19 federal agencies and departments while litigation continues.

The justices lifted a lower-court order that temporarily blocked plans to lay off thousands of federal workers, including at the State Department and the Social Security Administration, because the administration did not first consult with Congress.

In response to other emergency requests from the Trump administration, the Supreme Court has repeatedly sided with President Donald Trump's efforts to upend the federal bureaucracy. The court's conservative majority has permitted the administration to fire independent regulators and thousands of probationary workers while legal challenges play out in the lower courts.

But in this case, two of the liberal justices — Elena Kagan and Sonia Sotomayor — appear to have joined the conservatives in allowing the administration to plan reorganizations and reductions in the workforce. Sotomayor said it was because the administration had directed agencies to operate “consistent with applicable law.”

“The plans themselves are not before this Court, at this stage, and we thus have no occasion to consider whether they can and will be carried out consistent with the constraints of law,” wrote Sotomayor, who contended that the lower-court judge is still free to assess the legality of the

SEE LAYOFFS ON A5

At least 161 missing in Texas floods



RONALDO SCHEMIDT/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A helicopter flies over Camp Mystic along the Guadalupe River on Tuesday. Five children and a counselor remain missing from the camp.

Climate change: Heavier rainfall is fueling rising flood fatalities in the United States. A6

Climate Coach: How extreme weather is altering the summer camp experience. A7

How to help: Local officials have asked for monetary donations and heavy equipment. A7

109 DEAD, BUT TOLL COULD RISE FURTHER

Lawmakers ask to revisit bill on disaster readiness

BY ANUMITA KAUR, ANGIE ORELLANA HERNANDEZ AND PATRICK SVITEK

More than 160 people are known to be missing after devastating floods swept through Central Texas over the July Fourth weekend, Texas Gov. Greg Abbott (R) said Tuesday — raising the possibility that the death toll could surpass 200 in what is already one of the deadliest flood events in the past five decades.

“Just in the Kerr County area alone, there are 161 people who are known to be missing,” Abbott said at a news conference Tuesday. “We will not stop until every missing person is accounted for.”

Torrential downpours caused a surge of river water early Friday, producing a deluge that left 109 people dead. The disaster claimed the lives of more than two dozen children, shaking the region in a scene that Abbott has described as “nothing short of horrific.” The magnitude of the tragedy also exposed gaps in the region's ability to warn people about catastrophic weather

SEE FLOOD ON A6

Rubio impostor used AI voice to call top officials

BY JOHN HUDSON AND HANNAH NATANSON

An impostor pretending to be Secretary of State Marco Rubio contacted foreign ministers, a U.S. governor and a member of Congress by sending them voice and text messages that mimic Rubio's voice and writing style using artificial intelligence-powered software, according to a se-

nior U.S. official and a State Department cable obtained by The Washington Post.

U.S. authorities do not know who is behind the string of impersonation attempts but they believe the culprit was probably attempting to manipulate powerful government officials “with the goal of gaining access to information or accounts,” according to a cable sent by Rubio's office to

State Department employees.

Using both text messaging and the encrypted messaging app Signal, which the Trump administration uses extensively, the impostor “contacted at least five non-Department individuals, including three foreign ministers, a U.S. governor, and a U.S. member of Congress,” said the cable, dated July 3.

The impersonation campaign

began in mid-June when the impostor created a Signal account using the display name “Marco.Rubio@state.gov” to contact unsuspecting foreign and domestic diplomats and politicians, said the cable. The display name is not his real email address.

“The actor left voicemails on Signal for at least two targeted individuals and in one instance,

SEE RUBIO ON A8

Gabbard's team seeks reams of spy agency data

Access to emails, chat logs is desired to enforce administration's agenda

BY ELLEN NAKASHIMA, WARREN P. STROBEL AND AARON SCHAFER

A special team created by Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard has expressed a desire to gain access to emails and chat logs of the largest U.S. spy agencies with the aim of using artificial intelligence tools to ferret out what the administration deems as efforts to undermine its agenda, according to several people familiar with the matter.

The mission of the Director's Initiative Group, or DIG, is to enforce President Donald Trump's executive orders to end “weaponization” of the federal government, declassify documents, and halt diversity, equity and inclusion programs, according to Gabbard's office.

So far, none of the U.S. spy agencies approached has transferred the data, several people said.

The unprecedented interest in data by officials at the Office of the Director of National Intelligence startled some senior agency officials, who have expressed concerns about the counterintelligence and privacy risks of aggregating what could be a large amount of sensitive information that may include references to interceptions of electronic communications on overseas targets, said several U.S. officials and others familiar with aspects of the effort. Like most people interviewed for this article, they spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the matter's

SEE GABBARD ON A8

Wary of China, U.S. moves to bar some sales of farmland

BY CATE CADELL

U.S. Agriculture Department chief Brooke Rollins announced Tuesday that the U.S. government will move to ban sales of farmland nationwide to buyers tied to China and other foreign adversaries, citing threats to national security and food security — an effort that casts uncertainty over property currently held by China-linked investors.

Asked whether the U.S. government would seek to take back existing land owned by Chinese investors, Rollins said they are looking at “every available option” as part of a clawback effort and that an executive order from the White House will probably follow “very soon.”

In a joint news conference with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem, Rollins said that

the USDA will also work with state legislators to quickly push through laws that will ban further purchases, with a particular focus on parcels of land near U.S. military bases.

“With this announcement today we are taking this purpose and our American farmland back. American agriculture is not just about feeding our families but about protecting our nation and standing up to foreign adversaries who are buying our farmland, stealing our research and creating dangerous vulnerabilities,” said Rollins.

While the new plan also applies to adversaries such as Russia and Iran, it is largely aimed at China.

The percentage of total U.S. farmland owned by Chinese investors amounts to just 0.0003 percent and has declined sharply in recent years — down around 31

SEE FARMLAND ON A4



ARIS MESSINIS/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Acropolis assailed by excessive highs

Tourists, some wielding umbrellas for shade, gather Tuesday near the Acropolis in Athens. Greek officials closed the ancient citadel to visitors as a heat wave enveloped the country.

TSA will no longer require travelers to take off their shoes during security screenings

BY ANDREA SACHS, HANNAH SAMPSON, IAN DUNCAN AND ETHAN BECK

Travelers passing through airport security checkpoints will no longer have to remove their shoes,

reversing a rule that has been in effect since 2006.

Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem officially announced the end of the “shoes-off” travel policy at a news conference Tuesday at Reagan National Airport, but some airports had been

experimenting with the new security protocol for days.

Noem said advances in security technology have allowed the Transportation Security Administration to make the change while keeping travelers safe.

“We've evaluated the equip-

ment that every airport has and are fully confident [with] the no-shoes policy that we still have the security needs in place at every single checkpoint,” Noem said at the airport.

The majority of travelers will be allowed to pass through security

without removing their shoes, but there will be exceptions, Noem said. Security agents will still pull people aside if they deem it necessary.

Joe Shuker, an official in the TSA officers union, said earlier

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